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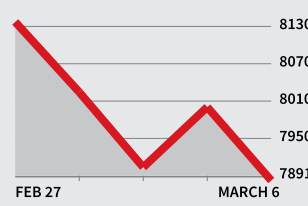
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Source
1. Google commissioned Kantar Sports Fan Research 2024, Deloitte analysis.
2. In an MMM meta-analysis we commissioned with Nielsen, on average, YouTube effectiveness was 24.11 times greater than Linear TV effectiveness across Total CPG MMMs that measured YouTube, Other Digital, and Linear TV from Jan'20- Sep'23 in India. According to a meta analysis of CPG MMM Studies by Analytic Edge in India, YouTube ROI was 3.0x of OTT Platforms ROI (2021-2024)

the hindu businessline

SENSEX 78918.90 (-2368.29)



IN FOCUS

	Week's close	Week's change
Nifty 50	24450.45	-728.20
P/E Ratio (Sensex)	21.67	-0.65
US Dollar (in ₹)	91.74	+0.77
Gold Std 10 gm (in ₹)	158115.00	-345
Silver 1 kg (in ₹)	260723.00	-5977

TENSE SITUATION.

West Asian exporters have begun withdrawing consignments stranded at ports and airports through BTT process **p3**



PULSE.

Midlife, ageing, mental health remain areas of darkness in health policies for women **p9**

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MONDAY SPECIALS.

BRANDLINE

For GenZ, timepieces are identity markers



A new trend is echoing across India's younger demographic: watches are transcending their utilitarian origins to become complex personal statements. Valued at \$4.62 b in 2026 and projected to reach \$7.52 b by 2031, the watch sector is forcing brands to negotiate between performance and appearance. Success depends on how homogeneously function is wrapped in identity and design. **p6**

LOGISTICS

Aircraft leasing gains altitude

In the steel-and-glass corridors of GIFT City, a quiet aviation revolution is gaining altitude. In just one year, aircraft leasing from India's maiden international financial services centre in Gandhinagar (Gujarat) has grown three-fold — a pace few other global hubs can claim. **p8**

Top NBFCs seek lower risk weights across loan segments

UNDER PRESSURE. Regulatory scrutiny by the RBI increases sharply over the past years

Piyush Shukla
Mumbai

Non-banking finance companies (NBFCs), especially the ones classified under upper-layer category, are seeking lowering of risk weights across loan categories. They say regulatory scrutiny by the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) has increased sharply over the past years and is on par with universal banks.

“Large NBFCs’ regulatory scrutiny has increased sharply. We have to mark higher risk weights across loan categories in comparison to banks, while also making higher provisions as we follow the ECL model and also maintain higher capital adequacy ratio,” said a senior official with a large NBFC. He added that NBFCs nudged the regulator about lowering risk weights in their last meeting with the RBI Governor Sanjay Malhotra.

According to Ajit Velonie, Senior Director at Crisil Rat-

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- NBFCs nudged the regulator about lowering risk weights in their last meeting with the RBI Governor
- NBFCs assign 100 per cent risk weight on most retail loan categories (except housing loans), while banks assign 75 per cent on the same loans which qualify as regulatory retail portfolio



ings, NBFCs assign 100 per cent risk weights on most retail loan categories (except housing loans) such as vehicle loans, MSME/loan against property and loans against gold jewellery, while banks assign 75 per cent on the same loans which qualify as regulatory retail portfolio.

RETAIL LOANS

“In corporate loans too, banks assign 20 per cent risk weight on AAA-rated corporates, 30 per cent on AA corporates and 50 per cent on A-rated corporates, while for NBFCs, there is no linkage to ratings, and they assign 100 per cent on corporate

loans,” added Velonie. NBFCs have been seeking a rejig in risk weights, especially on retail loans, as such loans form around 90 per cent of industry assets under management.

With enhanced regulatory scrutiny and strong buffers, NBFCs are asking the regulator to take a re-look and harmonise NBFCs’ risk weights for some retail lending segments.

RE-FINANCE WINDOW

NBFCs have long been demanding a dedicated re-finance window — similar to the National Housing Bank (NHB) for housing finance companies (HFCs) — and

approval for large NBFCs to accept public deposits, a licence which the RBI has not granted to any large NBFC for decades.

A host of NBFC sector officials say that large institutions such as Employees’ Provident Fund Organisation (EPFO) and Pension Fund Regulatory and Development Authority (PFRDA) tend to invest primarily in Central or State government securities.

Within corporates, it is primarily in non-convertible debentures (NCDs) issued by large-sized, AAA- or AA-rated NBFCs.

“Funding from banks for NBFCs overall had squeezed after the RBI hiked risk-weight on bank loans to NBFCs (which has now been rolled back). However, we have seen an increase in bank lending to NBFCs over the last three months. On the other hand, funds raised through other avenues such as NCDs remains a challenge for many A- or BBB-rated entities,” added Velonie.

IndiGo restarts Europe flights, Air India adds extra services to aid stranded flyers

Aneesh Phadnis
Mumbai

IndiGo has resumed wide-body flights to Europe after a seven-day pause, while Air India announced 78 extra services to Europe and the US on Sunday to aid stranded travellers. IndiGo operates to Amsterdam, London and Manchester on wet-leased Boeing 787-9 aircraft belonging to Norwegian airline Norse Atlantic.

A recommendation from the European Aviation Safety Agency, urging airlines to avoid the airspace over Gulf states, is said to have prompted flight cancellations. An IndiGo executive said the wet-leased 787 planes will not fly over the restricted airspace.

On Sunday, flight tracking website Flightradar24 showed IndiGo’s Mumbai-London flight taking a route south of Yemen into Africa and over Red Sea before proceeding to Europe.

Air India’s Delhi-London flights are taking 11 hours, nearly two hours more than the usual, due to changes in the flight routes.

Fuel burn has increased due to extended flying time, as well as the additional con-



GULF BOILS OVER. A recommendation from the European Aviation Safety Agency, urging airlines to avoid the airspace over Gulf states, is said to have prompted flight cancellations

tingency fuel being uplifted for possible diversions.

IN HIGH DEMAND

Meanwhile, Air India has announced extra flights to Europe and the US in response to sustained high demand. The airline will operate 78 extra flights to New York, London, Paris, Amsterdam, Frankfurt, Zurich, Male and Colombo between March 10 and 18. This will add 17,660 extra seats on nine routes in both directions.

“Despite the odds, Air India continues to maintain its scheduled services to Europe and North America, sustaining connectivity to several international gateways using alternative routings that are assessed as safe for opera-

tions,” said Air India’s Chief Commercial Officer, Nipun Aggarwal.

Regular commercial and repatriation flights continue from West Asia. IndiGo said it is operating to eight destinations in West Asia. Akasa Air, Air India and SpiceJet, too, are operating flights to the region. Qatar Airways is operating limited flights from Europe to Doha, but scheduled flights remain suspended. Operations at Bahrain and Kuwait, too, remain shut.

Over 52,000 Indians flew in from West Asia between March 1 and 7 with the partial resumption of flights. These include both in-transit passengers and short-term visa visitors to West Asia.

INDIA CHAMPIONS, AGAIN



STRONG PARTNERSHIP. India won the T20 World Cup trophy for the second successive time, beating New Zealand by 96 runs in the finals on Sunday at Ahmedabad. Abhishek Sharma (left) celebrates with teammate Sanju Samson after scoring half century **p11**

I-T dept’s nationwide crackdown targets restaurants in ₹70,000 crore tax scam

Dalip Singh
New Delhi

The Income Tax department on Sunday launched a nationwide survey at 60-70 locations to unravel a deeply entrenched software-based network that restaurants across States and Union Territories are using for massive tax evasion.

The Central Board of Direct Taxes (CBDT) decided to go in for a crackdown across the country after a routine inspection at biryani restaurants in Hyderabad last month unravelled concealed sales, widely estimated to be around ₹70,000 crore.

Sources privy to the CBDT offensive stated that the sur-

vey began on Sunday morning across 60 to 70 locations, covering restaurants as well as common software data management companies.

POPULAR RESTAURANTS

At least four popular restaurants in the national capital were covered in the survey, including a leading food joint on Pandara Road and another one known for offering North Indian curries. According to sources, there are six restaurant locations in Tamil Nadu, two in Kerala and four in Gujarat where the sleuths carried out surprise check of records and data to expose the racket.

Sources said a comprehensive picture of tax evasion would appear after the

survey gets over. The I-T sleuths, after analysing around 60 terabytes of data of 1.77 lakh food joints through AI and data analytics forensic tools, found out that restaurants were indulging in massive under billing of sales in tax filings. The transactions took place over seven years starting in 2019.

Sources said one of the companies under inspection uses Petpuja — a point-of-sale (PoS) billing and restaurant management software used by a large number of eateries across the country. It manages orders, billing, inventory, GST records and payment tracking and stores data on central servers, allowing restaurants to manage bills digitally. The

I-T officials were astonished to find out the common modus operandi: to manipulate the software, restaurants would initially record all sales and later delete them at the time of filing GST.

INBUILT FEATURES

The software had inbuilt features to allow mass deletion of data periodically within seconds. According to officials, it also enabled reducing the value on bills — another under-invoicing tactic to pay less taxes.

The I-T department, in its initial round of digging of data at Hyderabad, found out that under-billing of ₹13,317 crore was identified, specifically from deleted invoices.

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QUICKLY.

Amudhavalli Ranganathan
to head CII IWN TN



Chennai: The CII Indian Women Network (IWN) Tamil Nadu has announced new leadership at its flagship summit, Thaaragai 2026. Amudhavalli Ranga- nathan, Director, CavinKare & Executive Director, CK Group of Educational Institutions, has taken over as Chairwoman of CII IWN Tamil Nadu. The summit brought together over 400 leaders from industry, policymakers, healthcare and academia. Held under the theme “Give to Gain: Rise, Radiate. Redefine”, the summit served as a platform for discussions around women’s health, safety, entrepreneurship and workforce participation, while highlighting the importance of collaborative action between industry, government and academia to build a more inclusive ecosystem. **OUR BUREAU**

CPSEs’ capital expenditure nears revised annual target ahead of fiscal year end

POWERFUL DRIVERS. Energy companies lead spending as outlay hits ₹7.40 lakh crore in 11 months of the current fiscal

Shishir Sinha
New Delhi

With strong support from energy companies, the overall capital expenditure by Central Public Sector Enterprises (CPSEs) and four government organisations has almost achieved their revised target a month before the end of the fiscal year, data from Public Enterprises Department of Finance Ministry showed. However, it is important to note that the overall target has now been lowered to nearly ₹7.47 lakh crore from ₹7.85 lakh crore for 60 CPSEs, including four organisations from 18 central ministries and departments. Data showed that these entities spent nearly ₹7.40 lakh

crore during 11 months of the current fiscal, which is over 99 per cent of the revised target. This is almost like actual during the corresponding period of last fiscal. During the last fiscal, these entities achieved 102 per cent of the target and officials expect that same for the current year too. **SPENDING SURGE** February saw expenditure of over ₹72,000 crore, which is the highest in three months of the current fiscal and the second highest in the current fiscal. It is important to note here that CPSEs such as NLC and NTPC and one government organisation NHAH have already exceeded their annual targets.

Top spenders			
(All figures in ₹ crore/2025-26)			
CPSE/Govt orgaisation	Target	Actuals in Apr-Feb	% of target
NLC	5,078	7,759	152.78
HPCL	11,500	16,302	141.76
NTPC	29,000	40,029	138.03
Mangalore Refinery	827	1,079.57	130.54
NHAH	1,70,266	2,03,694	119.63
Powergrid	28,000	33,490	119.61
Dedicated Freight Corridor	4,371	4,134	94.58
Indian Oil	34,700	31,794	91.49
Railway Board	2,59,982	2,35,062	90.41
ONGC	34,900	28,111	80.55

Source: DPE

NLC (formerly Neyveli Lignite Corporation) was at the top, followed by Hindustan Petroleum and NTPC. Meanwhile, the NHAH and the Railway Board spent around 120 per cent and 90 per cent of their respective targets.

framework for CPSE evaluation. This includes capex, return on networth or return on capital employed, export and import as per cent of revenue, EBITDA as per cent of revenue and asset turnover ratio. This data has come at a time when the Centre’s capex surged by over 11 per cent during April-January period of FY26 compared to the corresponding period of FY25, as reported by the Controller General of Accounts (CGA). Key contributions came from Railways (89 per cent of the revised estimates), road (86 per cent of RE) and capital outlay on defence services (78 per cent of RE), besides others. The government has revised the capex during the current fiscal to ₹10.96 lakh

crore, of which over ₹8.42 lakh crore has been spent during April-January period. Higher spending by infrastructure ministries is expected to have a positive impact on the overall growth number. **PRIVATE CAPEX** Higher spending by CPSEs and government organisations are critical as not much improvement is seen in private capex. It may be noted that a forward looking survey on private capex investment intentions by the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation indicated around 25 per cent decline in intended private capex in FY26 to ₹4.88 lakh crore against ₹6.56 lakh crore in FY25.

Economic growth may suffer due to conflict: SBI

Our Bureau
Mumbai

The Israel-Iran conflict may have short-term impact on India’s remittances and crude oil imports, according to SBI’s economic research department. They warned that a prolonged war and higher oil prices may slow down economic growth, widen India’s current account deficit (CAD) and push up inflation. SBI economists assessed that there is 5 per cent chance that higher prices may still result in slowing of inward remittances.

REMITTANCE GROWTH India’s personal remittances increased 15 per cent to \$138 billion in FY25 from \$119 billion in FY24. GCC (Gulf Cooperation Council) countries account for around 38 per cent of the total remittances. “India imports nearly 90 per cent of its crude oil requirements. About two million barrels per day of this, out of 5.5 million, transits through the Strait of Hormuz, which the US Energy Information Administration has described as the “world’s most important oil transit chokepoint”. “In 2025 H1, oil flow through the strait averaged 20.9 million barrels per day (b/d), or 26 per cent of global petroleum liquids consumption,” said Soumya Kanti Ghosh, Group Chief Economic Advisor, SBI. SBI economists noted that over the years, India has strategically shifted to import oil from more than 40 countries, more from Russia since 2022. Though India does not buy any oil from Iran, Hormuz is crucial for India as 40 per cent of oil imports still pass through this waterway between Iran and Oman. They noted that the forward contracts booked for future delivery of oil will partially be offset by US’ reprieve on purchase of Russian oil through a 30-day window.

Schengen tightens visa timelines; Italy mandates two-month rule for MICE travellers

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

Europe is tightening the visa rulebook for Indian travellers. Italy has mandated a two-month advance submission for MICE visas while several Schengen countries are working on rigid processing timelines, signalling stricter compliance norms for Indian travellers amid rising outbound demand. Ahead of the peak summer travel season, Indian travellers and corporate mobility planners may need to schedule Europe-bound trips much earlier for 2026, after Italy mandated a two-month advance submission requirement for group and MICE (meetings, incentives, conferences and exhibitions)

visa applications. This is one of several procedural tightening measures emerging across major visa destinations. **RIGID PROCESSING** VFS Global outlined a series of operational updates across key countries that signal a broader shift toward defined processing timelines, tighter scrutiny of documentation and reduced discretion in high-volume markets, as part of its interaction with travel trade partners. The move is part of a broader, system-wide tightening by European missions. At a recent interaction with travel trade partners, VFS Global detailed a shift toward rigid processing timelines, digital-first



STRICTER NORMS

- Germany will require, from January, family reunion applicants to upload documents through its consular service portal prior to submission
- Hungary has mandated a minimum 15-day processing period for short-stay visas
- The Netherlands has indicated processing timelines ranging between 15 and 45 days.
- Indian visitors must hold an e-visa linked to their passport through a UKVI account

frameworks, and intensified documentation scrutiny across major hubs. Italy has introduced one

Bengaluru, Hyderabad and Chennai, visa appointments can no longer be booked using an agent’s email id or phone number. Registration must be done using the applicant’s own credentials. More significantly for corporate India, Italy has mandated that MICE and group visa applications must reach the consulate at least two months in advance. The rule effectively eliminates flexibility for last-minute incentive trips, trade delegations and conference travel during peak European travel seasons. **RULE-BASED SHIFT** For travel companies and event planners, Europe-bound group travel is increasingly becoming a calendar-driven compliance exer-

cise. Other Schengen countries have also introduced stricter procedural requirements. Germany will require, from January, family reunion applicants to upload documents through its consular service portal prior to submission. Hungary has mandated a minimum 15-calendar-day processing period for short-stay visas, reducing the scope for urgent filings. The Netherlands has introduced colour-document submission requirements and indicated processing timelines ranging between 15 and 45 days. Collectively, these changes suggest a system-wide shift from discretionary handling toward structured, rule-based visa processing frameworks across

parts of the Schengen region. The UK has also completed its transition to a fully digital entry framework. From February 25, Indian visitors must hold an e-visa linked to their passport through a UKVI account, with airlines required to verify digital authorisation at boarding. The move replaces physical visa stickers as part of the UK’s phased border digitisation programme. While biometric enrolment continues at visa centres, passports no longer need to be retained during processing. VFS Global has also expanded its client government portfolio, adding Montenegro, Moldova, and Algeria to its network in recent months.

India a stable, trustworthy AI partner: Tata Comm Chief

Our Bureau
Chennai

“India is a geopolitically stable and trustworthy partner in the global AI ecosystem and its strength to use the right set of digital tools around AI will be a game-changer” NG Subramanian, Chairman, Tata Communications and Tata Elxsi, said. Subramanian was addressing the SASTRA PACT for IMPACT event at SASTRA University in Thanjavur, where he appreciated the educational institution for collaborating with different organisations in multiple domains to leverage AI’s growing opportunities and build indigenous capacity. **‘DHARMIC AI’** The industry executive also stressed on the need to teach AI models and not

train AI models with anecdotal references, particularly emphasising on ‘Dharmic AI’. **MOUs SIGNED** At the event, SASTRA signed MoUs with Zoho Corporation, City Union Bank, Centific Inc, IIT Ropar, Greaves Cotton, PRODAPT and nStore for collaborative work in AI, physical AI, agriculture sustainability, software engineering, advanced manufacturing and mathematical modelling. Zoho CEO Shailesh Kumar Davey; City Union Bank CEO & MD N Kamakodi; Rajeev Ahuja, Director of IIT Ropar; RL Narasimhan, Centific India Head, and Dhansharee Bhat, CDO of PRODAPT were among those present at the MoU signing. The Vice-Chancellor of SASTRA, SVaidhyasubramaniam welcomed the gathering.

Insurance agents turn to mutual fund distribution as investors flock to SIPs

Suresh P Iyengar
Mumbai

The growing popularity of systematic investment plans in mutual funds and rising demand from investors have been forcing many insurance agents to take up MF distribution. The MF industry has added 51,002 MF distributors last year against 47,297 in 2024, an increase of 8 per cent. Overall, the MF industry has 3.31 lakh AMFI registration numbers (ARNs) and EUIN (employee unique identification number) holders. Of these, individual MFDs were 1.75 lakh, making up about 53 per cent of the total ARNs. About 45 per cent of individual MFDs are located in B30 (beyond top 30) cities. **SIPs ON A HIGH** The number of new SIP re-

gistered has hit an all-time of 74.11 lakh last month with inflows touching ₹30,002 crore. Roughly 94 per cent of life insurance portfolios consist of savings-oriented, rather than pure protection products. The term and life insurance sector has lost its sheen after the government made tax-free income up to ₹11.50 lakh. Also, the adoption of new tax regime has been much faster as it offers lower tax rate without any set-off on specific investments. To start with, insurance agents have to clear the NISM Series V-A certification and obtain an ARN. Many online financial services platforms are also simplifying transition for insurance agents by assisting with the certification, regulatory onboarding and providing technology infrastructure. Aditya Agarwal, Co-founder, Wealthy.in, said that



with LIC alone serving over 40 crore customers and India’s insurance ecosystem having nearly 30 lakh agents, a gradual shift toward MF distribution is already visible and catching pace. **BROADER APPROACH** “Insurance agents often build trusted relationships with clients over decades. As clients’ financial needs grow beyond protection to wealth creation, they naturally turn to the same advisor for guidance to invest their surplus savings or proceeds from maturing policies,” he said. Wealthy onboards nearly

350 distributors every month. Of these, about 40 per cent of the new MF distributors are with insurance background, he added. After spending nearly three decades as an insurance agent, Kalidassan Malavizhi decided to expand his offerings last year as client preferences began to shift. “Many of my customers started asking for investment options beyond insurance, especially MFs and equities,” he said. Today, his business mix reflects this diversification, with about 40 per cent in insurance, 30 per cent in MFs and about 20 per cent in stocks. While commissions from MFs are lower compared to insurance products, Kalidassan said the move has helped him build deeper relationships with clients by providing a broader financial planning approach.

RBI eases norm for AU SFB’s transition to universal bank

Our Bureau
Mumbai

The RBI has exempted the promoters/promoter group of AU Small Finance Bank (AU SFB) from the requirement that they hold stake in the transitioned universal bank through a non-operative financial holding company (NOFHC). When the RBI gave its in-principle approval on August 7, 2025, for AU SFB’s transition from a small finance bank to a universal bank, it had stipulated that the shareholding of the promoters/promoter group in the transitioned universal bank be held through an NOFHC. But pursuant to the bank’s request, the central bank has replaced the aforesaid stipulation, AU SFB said in a regulatory filing. “This requirement for NOFHC will now be applicable on the transitioned universal bank, if the bank or its promoter

(including promoter group) proposes to establish any group entity in the future,” it added. So, in case the bank or its promoter/promoter group wants to get into any other business like mutual fund or insurance after becoming a universal bank, they will need to form NOFHC. **LICENCE FILING** AU SFB said it will submit its application for the final universal banking licence, in line with the RBI’s letter dated August 7, 2025, conveying its in-principle approval for transition, under the guidance of its Board and within the stipulated timelines. The RBI’s in-principle approval is valid for 18 months. In Q3 ended December 31, 2025, the bank’s total deposits were up 23.3 per cent y-o-y to ₹1,38,415 crore. Advances rose 19.3 per cent y-o-y to ₹1,29,898 crore. Net profit rose 26 per cent y-o-y to ₹668 crore.

Women constitute over 30 per cent of AI-led roles in India even as Anthropic warns of labour impact

Vallari Sanzgiri
Mumbai

Women constitute over 30 per cent of AI-led roles in India even as Anthropic, in a recent study, highlighted them as the more exposed group due to AI. Women account for 31 per cent of the new roles emerging because of AI and related emerging technologies in India, as per data shared by hiring firms. Jobs pertaining to AI, data science, analytics, cybersecurity and others report a growth in the number of women taking such roles. **AI EXPOSURE** Anthropic used US data to look at the impact of AI on



LONELY AT THE TOP. Women hold only 23 per cent of leadership roles and only 17 per cent in top executive or C-suite positions: Instahyre GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCKPHOTO

the labour market and said women are 16 per cent more likely to be among the more exposed groups. However, Indian data show that women have a consid-

erable presence in AI jobs. According to talent acquisition platform Instahyre, the share of women in such roles has increased from 26 per cent a year

earlier, indicating a steady rise in women entering AI-driven and future-tech jobs. Similarly, CIEL HR talked about how women are more represented in knowledge-intensive and digital roles such as design engineering, R&D, data analytics, product management, quality assurance and regulatory or compliance functions. **LEADERSHIP ROLES** Overall, women account for about 35 per cent of entry-level roles and 36 per cent of the overall workforce, reflecting strong participation driven by campus hiring. However, the representation drops significantly at the senior levels, with women holding only around

23 per cent of leadership roles, and only 17 per cent in top executive or C-suite positions, said Instahyre. **‘TALENT PIPELINE’** “The numbers show a clear structural gap: though almost one in three tech professionals entering the industry are women, fewer than one in four make it to leadership, underscoring the persistent progression challenge in India’s tech talent pipeline,” said Sarbojit Mallick, Co-founder, Instahyre. CIEL too reported how women hold only 12-16 per cent of leadership roles in sectors such as semiconductors, GCCs and e-commerce, while aerospace and defence have just 7.4 per cent representation at the leadership level.

Federal Bank to ‘restructure’ wealth management services tie up with Equirus

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Federal Bank said its existing arrangement with Equirus Capital Private Ltd for wealth management services will be “restructured”. The bank intends to invest more and create its own franchise in the wealth management business as part of the next phase of growth. **STRATEGIC EXPANSION** As part of this strategic expansion, and to align with the bank’s evolving product and service architecture for affluent and UHNI (ultra high net-worth individual) clients, the existing arrangement between Federal Bank and Equirus Capital Private Ltd for wealth management services will be restructured, the Bank said in a statement. Customers who avail them-

selves of wealth management services through the existing arrangement with Equirus will continue to do so without disruption under the current framework. Federal Bank, which launched its wealth management platform and its first Wealth Hub, said it continues to hold 8.69 per cent stake in Equirus. The bank and Equirus will continue to collaborate to fulfil the investment needs of UHNI category customers by offering select products and services from the Equirus wealth management suite, per the statement. The bank’s wealth management business will be led by Virendra Somwanshi, it added. KVS Manian, MD & CEO, Federal Bank, said, “The Equirus partnership enabled the Bank to establish a strong foundation in the wealth management business. In the next

phase of growth, we would like to invest more and create our own franchise in this space”. Ajay Garg, MD Equirus Capital, said, “As envisaged in the partnership, we had entered into the wealth management business 7 years ago and have been able to establish ourselves as one of the top 10 players in the wealth management business with presence across 23 cities”.

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Stress management

CAD may widen, but is no cause for alarm

India’s external account had been relatively stable over the past year, despite the US’ tariff offensive and foreign portfolio outflows. This, however, could worsen if the US-Israel- Iran war drags on, essentially on account of the country’s import dependence to meet crude oil demand.



The current account deficit (CAD) for the April to December 2025 period was \$30.1 billion, which is about 1 per cent of GDP. This is an improvement from the \$36.6 billion or 1.3 per cent of GDP in the same period of FY25. The CAD has remained in control, despite capital outflows and a rising merchandise trade deficit, thanks to services exports. Rising oil imports could alter this fragile equilibrium. The trade deficit in petroleum, oil and lubricants products already accounts for a significant 37 per cent of the total deficit in goods trade. According to estimates by economists, a \$10 increase in crude oil price per barrel can expand India’s CAD as a percentage of GDP by 30-40 basis points. The CAD had spiked to record highs during the previous Gulf wars in 1990s and in 2003.

Meanwhile, goods trade deficit increased 10 per cent to \$251 billion between April and December 2025, partially due to disruptions caused to commodity exports on account of the tariffs. While the bilateral trade deals signed with the EU, the UK and the US may help in bridging this gap in non-oil goods, crude oil prices will likely end up widening the deficit. Capital account flows, too, could take an adverse turn. During geopolitical crises, global portfolio investors sell risky assets such as emerging market equities and move funds into safe havens such as gold. After being net buyers of Indian equity and debt in February, foreign portfolio investors have already pulled out ₹20,819 crore from Indian markets in the first week of March. Similarly, NRI deposits, which had already declined 16 per cent in the first three quarters of this fiscal year due to weakness in the rupee, can take a knock. About 40 per cent of inward remittances come from countries in West Asia such as the UAE, Saudi Arabia, Kuwait and Qatar. Foreign direct investment from this region can also be impacted as these countries rebuild their facilities.

Services exports have been a silver lining, mitigating the impact of a widening goods trade deficit. These exports amounted to \$156 billion between April and December 2025, registering a growth of 15 per cent over the same period in FY25. With over 85 per cent of these channelled to the US, the UK and Europe, these exports may remain unaffected by the ongoing war — unless the conflict carries on, hurting IT services demand globally. The resilience displayed by services exports in times of crises is notable. Policy support to exports in segments such as accounting, technical and legal consultancy, is worth considering. With forex reserves at \$728 billion, Reserve Bank of India can surely defend the currency. The situation is stressful, but manageable.

OTHER VOICES.

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.

EUROPE

China admits it has an economic problem

Economic reality comes for us all in the end — yes, even China’s Communist Party. So it is that officials this week reduced their economic growth-target for the coming year to the lowest level since 1991. They’ll still probably struggle to hit it. Beijing’s target range for GDP growth this year, 4.5%-5%, is less a goal than a concession. Official economic data are notoriously prone to political monkeying by the Party, and there’s rarely any doubt that those data will show China achieved whatever goal the bosses have set. A lower target is thus an admission that not even President Xi Jinping thinks he can pretend growth will be faster. A period of slower growth would be acceptable if the pain had a purpose. Since 2020 the economy has been rebalancing from over-reliance on real-estate. (NEW YORK, MARCH 6)



How UAE air defences turned Iran’s attacks into failure

In its effective and highly professional handling of the Iranian missile and drone attacks it has faced, the United Arab Emirates has demonstrated exceptional readiness and capability in containing threats to its national security. It has managed the repercussions of such crises with the utmost professionalism, preserving the calm and stability that define it as an oasis of security and safety — an asset that represents one of its most valuable investments and a cornerstone of the attractiveness of its development model. The clearest evidence of the UAE’s exceptional defence preparedness lies in the statistics. The country was subjected to a magnitude of attacks comparable to the total faced by the rest of the Gulf Cooperation Council states combined. (DUBAI, MARCH 6)

LINE & LENGTH.



TCA SRINIVASA RAGHAVAN

One of the most difficult but largely successful endeavours of human societies, throughout history, has been to prevent the wrong sort of person, a nut, from becoming the head of the government. And, by and large, various societies have done a great job of this.

But, every now and then, completely unexpectedly, a total nut becomes the head of the government. It always shocks everyone. After all, no security system is totally foolproof.

That, however, is to be expected and not very important. What is important is that each of these nuts has always completely rebooted the existing systems.

Nothing is ever the same again after they have gone. It doesn’t matter if things become worse or better after their rule. What matters is that things have changed.

The list of such rulers given below is far from complete or chronological. But it illustrates my point that nuts cause irrevocable change. Not just that. In the last 1,500 years these nuts have been almost entirely from the West, or of white people.

Not all these rulers were clinically insane but they were close enough as to not matter. However, it is a thin line between being properly mad or being highly eccentric, mercurial, impetuous, narcissistic, spoiled and so on.

THE NUT LIST

George the Third of England was probably bipolar but who knows what it actually was. Everyone thought he was mad. He began the fight with England’s American colonies and ended up losing them in 1775 when the Americans declared independence. The world has never been the same again, that too in such a lot of ways that you can take your pick about whether you like the changes or not.

France was not much better. It had a king, Charles the Sixth who signed away the French throne to Henry V of England. Imagine that. Just gifted it to a arch enemy.

Napoleon, also a Frenchman, wasn’t mad in the sense old Georgie Porgie was but he also wanted total control, first of France and then of Europe. He even

Nidhi Amit Satija
Abhinav Banka

In discussions on financial sector development, the focus often is on the supply of credit while underestimating the architecture through which credit flows. The Trade Receivables Discounting System (TReDS) is one such institutional innovation that addresses the chronic inefficiency of delayed payments to MSMEs and the resultant working capital stress. Budget 2026-27, read alongside the 2025 Financial Sector Assessment Program (FSAP) report of the World Bank, suggests that the government has recognised TReDS not merely as a fintech platform but as an instrument of structural reform.

More than ₹7.5 lakh crore has already been financed through TReDS since its inception. Annual volumes have crossed ₹2 lakh crore in recent years, and monthly throughput has exceeded ₹30,000 crore recently. Yet, when placed against the scale of India’s MSME receivables, which run into several lakh crores at any point in time, TReDS penetration remains modest.

This divergence between the potential and actual outcomes is exactly the concern highlighted by the World Bank under FSAP.

Accordingly, the Bank recommended three interlinked measures: operationalising a second window and a credit guarantee scheme for factoring; incentivising large buyers to upload invoices and mandating such uploads for state-owned enterprises (SOEs); and leveraging CGTMSE through a first-loss portfolio approach with sound financial

BELOW THE LINE



Sage advice

On March 9, two luminaries in India will celebrate their birthday — politician, philosopher and ex Maharaja of J&K Karan Singh turns 95; and politician and bibliophile Shashi Tharoor turns 75. At an event

on Friday to launch a biography of Karan Singh, the two shared the stage and recounted some fascinating stories. Describing how he won from Udhampur four times but lost an election for the first time when he shifted his seat to Jammu leading him to renounce politics altogether, Singh told Tharoor: “You have now won four times from Thiruvananthapuram, but please, for god’s sake, don’t make the mistake I did and stick to your constituency!” ChatGPT perils A little bird has raised concerns over bureaucrats trying to prepare their notes using ChatGPT. Information on the AI platform is based on other

information it taps from the web, and it could be dangerous. These platforms could be noting the IP address of the bureaucrat, and the Centre should issue an advisory asking them to refrain. Such efforts stop the bureaucrats from “critical thinking,” says the bird. Not bowled over by cricket The President of Finland, Alexander Stubb, ended his three day India visit with a fireside chat at a business summit in Mumbai. While most of the conversation was on pressing issues, of wars, tariffs and trade, it ended on a lighter note. Asked if he watched cricket during his India trip, Stubb said he didn’t. “I

know India beat England in the semi-final, and just to explain, for Finns there is nothing better than beating Sweden in ice-hockey and we just did it in Winter Olympics.” Though he missed cricket, Stubb made it a point to watch the movie *Dhurandhar* before coming to India. “My son sent me a message, ‘You have to watch it’, and I did. I know there is a sequel coming,” Stubb said, drawing applause from the audience. Filling a top post The Ministry of Commerce has invited applications for the post of Director, Basmati Development Export Foundation (BDEF). Industry observers wonder whether the age

limit has been set at 65 to accommodate retired IAS officers. They ask why there is this compulsion to engage retired officers. Also, has this advertisement been placed because a couple of Basmati exporters’ associations have sought a separate board for Basmati? At the same time, the post of Director (Finance) in the Agricultural and Processed Food Products Export Development Authority (APEDA) has been vacant for over two-and-a-half years. Does this mean the APEDA Chairman wants to keep the financial powers, too? Our Bureaus

The nut paradox of democracy

Nuts are safer in democracies than in other forms of government.

attacked Egypt in 1798 although he wasn’t the president. No one knows why. But it helped him personally because he came back to France and grabbed power.

Spain was really unlucky. It had three crazy monarchs. Austria, too, had one. All these fellows pretty much wrecked their kingdom and its economy. They also changed European equations forever.

Then there was that German king, Kaiser Wilhelm II. He started World War I in 1914 because he was insanely jealous of his cousin, who was King of England. This, when the British empire was at its peak. No surprise that he lost the war

The procedure for removing an unfit head of government may exist but it’s on paper only. The process is designed to fail because a democratically elected leader can only be removed democratically, that is, by the electorate

and had to go into exile. The world changed massively after that.

Germany soon produced another even bigger nut. Fifteen years after the Kaiser ran off in 1918, it elected Adolf Hitler. This guy started World War II and again changed the world forever in ways that are still affecting it. Nuclear weapons are a case in point.

Closer home we have been extraordinarily lucky to have had just one crazy ruler, Muhammad bin Tughlak. He was cruel, generous, temperamental, mercurial, rational, religious, etc., but, ultimately, a fool. He has been described by historian P Bhaskar Reddy as being “hot-headed, proud to the very core, poor judge of human nature and above all never bothered to give weight and value to the suggestions given by his ministers.” Ahem!

THE PARADOX OF VIRTUE

But we should not become complacent. In a democracy you never know where and when a nut will take over the government.

The problem here is not merely a nut getting elected. It’s also how to prevent that nut from causing massive

disruption. No one knows in advance.

An abiding mystery in this regard is why such madmen are not removed from office. Even in monarchies, the powers of a mad monarch have been curbed by sequestration. It hasn’t always worked fully but it’s had a fair amount of success.

Democracies, however, fare very badly on this score. The procedure for removing an unfit head of government may exist but it’s on paper only. It’s hardly ever been used because it’s nearly impossible to use.

Indeed, the process is designed to fail because a democratically elected leader can only be removed democratically, that is, by the electorate.

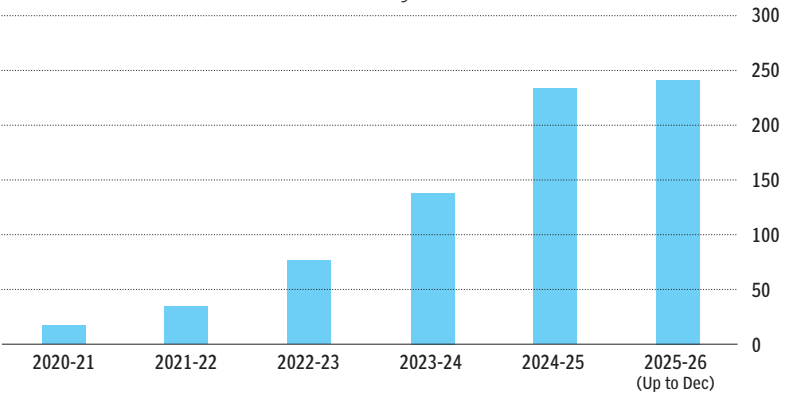
That’s the reason nuts are safer in democracies than in other forms of government. The one exception was recently in Korea where a president was impeached successfully. In fact, the Koreans have done it twice. The first time was in 1990 when they got rid of President Park Chung-hee.

But apart from that do let me know if there are any other instances of a nut being removed from office by the legislature. Indeed, that’s why, sometimes it takes nuts to remove nuts.

Scaling TReDS for fostering MSME-led growth

The Budget has proposals that will make TReDS a vehicle for sustainable credit deepening, easing working capital stress

Invoices financed over the years



Source: Authors’ calculation from RBI data

modelling and regulatory oversight. The latest Budget’s proposals align, almost point by point, to these recommendations.

Consider first the proposal to mandate TReDS as the transaction settlement platform for all CPSEs’ purchases from MSMEs. This is more than an administrative directive. It addresses the asymmetry of power in buyer-supplier relationships. When large public sector buyers delay invoice confirmation or payment, MSMEs bear the liquidity burden. By requiring CPSEs to transact through TReDS, the government introduces predictability, transparency and enforceability into the receivables chain. It also creates a benchmark for private corporates.

Second, the introduction of a CGTMSE-backed credit guarantee mechanism for invoice discounting directly operationalises the FSAP’s call to scale factoring through risk-sharing

and complements the RBI’s recent decision to raise the collateral-free lending limit for MSMEs from ₹10 lakh to ₹20 lakh. While the higher unsecured limit lowers entry barriers for borrowers, a first-loss guarantee mitigates lender-side risk, addressing the core constraint in receivables financing, the perception and pricing of credit risk, rather than a shortage of liquidity. Together, these measures create a balanced framework that crowds in banks and NBFCs to expands MSMEs credit access.

INFORMATION SYMMETRY

Third, the linking of the Government e-Marketplace with TReDS reflects a recognition that information symmetry is foundational to efficient markets. Government e-Marketplace has become a significant channel for public procurement from MSMEs.

By enabling financiers on TReDS to

access verified procurement data, the reform reduces due diligence costs, mitigates fraud risk and shortens turnaround times. In economic terms, it reduces transaction costs and enhances allocative efficiency.

Fourth, the proposal to develop TReDS receivables as asset-backed securities is perhaps the most forward-looking element. A secondary market for pooled receivables will allow financiers to recycle capital and diversify risk. It integrates invoice discounting into India’s broader debt capital market ecosystem. In doing so, it also deepens financial markets, an objective that the FSAP consistently associates with resilience and growth.

MACROECONOMIC CONTEXT

When receivables are locked up, production cycles slow, investment gets deferred and credit costs rise. There is also a financial stability dimension as informal trade credit chains are opaque and can amplify stress during downturns. TReDS brings these exposures into a regulated framework under RBI’s oversight. The combination of mandatory participation by CPSEs, calibrated credit guarantees and eventual securitisation enhance transparency while dispersing risk across a broader investor base. This, in turn, has positive bearing on reducing the NPA levels for the enterprises, particularly the small and medium ones.

In the journey towards becoming a developed economy, efficiency gains in working capital cycles may not capture headlines. Yet they cumulatively matter.

The writers are IES officers in the Ministry of Finance. Views are personal



ON THE CAMPAIGN
TRAIL.

Brands went splashy and colourful for Holi, even as they pulled out all the familiar Women’s Day tropes of overcoming biases and breaking various ceilings

Carefree celebration

Marico’s Holi campaign for its Parachute Advanced Gold Coconut Hair Oil tries to get people to overcome their fear about Holi colours and skin and hair damage. Rooted in the insight that during Holi many run away from colours, the brand makes a call to run towards them, backed by the protection of coconut oil. “Na-na wali nahi, Nariyal wali Holi,” it says. The digital film, conceptualised by Tonic Worldwide, shows women running into a vibrant sea of colours. The campaign also included reels featuring dermatologists explaining the science behind hair oiling during Holi, curated Holi starter kits delivered to hundreds of influencers across the country, and an on-ground engagement by creators Prannay Joshi and Sneha Namanandi with consumers at Mumbai’s Marine Drive.

Don’t assume

Online food ordering platform Zomato’s new campaign highlights the biases women delivery partners experience during their shifts. Through a series of everyday moments across the delivery journey — from order pick-up at the restaurant to the scooter ride, and delivery at the customer’s doorstep — women delivery partners encounter curious stares and unexpected questions at every step. Taking a cinematic spin, the delivery partners in the film address these reactions with light-hearted lessons. “Order karo, assume nahi,” as they say. According to the brand, there are more than 3,500 monthly active women delivery partners, handling more than 5 lakh orders.

Skin in the game

To mark Women’s Day, Raaga Professional, the professional skincare brand from Cavinkare, launched ‘Beyond Beauty’, a campaign that tries to promote a more inclusive view of beauty. Created in partnership with independent creative agency KALI, the campaign saw a series of posters across social spaces, each carrying an invitation to rethink long-held assumptions about the “ideal” beauty standards. Raaga Professional also sent a curated palette of Indian skin tones to a hundred women who actively shape salon and beauty culture. Instead of a standard progression, the centre of the palette held a mirror labelled “YOU’RS”, reframing the idea of the “most desirable” skin tone.

The changing man

Even as the noise was around Women’s Day, Raymond Lifestyle launched the latest iteration in its iconic ‘The Complete Man’ campaign. The new ad film, titled ‘Homecoming’, captures the choices made by the modern man that reflect empathy, balance, and presence. The film specifically speaks to the modern father transitioning from a mere breadwinner to a hands-on, nurturing anchor of the family. It features a man returning home after a long, exhausting day, still tethered to work. But in one small, decisive moment, he chooses to disconnect not just from his phone but also his work, and step into his most important role — being present for his family. Conceptualised by Omnicom, the ad film, which debuted during the final matches of the T20 World Cup, will also be seen on the big screen when *Dhurandhar2* is released.

NUGGETS.

Goafest dates announced

The 19th edition of Goafest, ad and marketing world’s mega festival, will be held in Goa between May 20 and 22. The festival will also host the ‘ABBY Awards Powered by One Show 2026’, which celebrates and honours creativity. Making the announcement, Srinivasan K Swamy, President of Advertising Agencies Association of India, said, “We aim to spark new conversations, fresh perspectives, and fuel the future of advertising and marketing.” Meanwhile, The Advertising Club (TAC), which conducts the Abby awards, has said there will be some new categories for Creative Abby 2026. The last date for submission of entries is April 6. The entry form is live on the TAC website. The new categories are ‘Social Content and Influencer Marketing’, ‘Creative Commerce’, ‘Use of Data’ and ‘B2B’.

TAC’s identity refresh

Recently, the seven-decade-old The Advertising Club (TAC) had a brand identity refresh to keep pace with the AI era. At the heart of the new identity is the idea of TAC as “the beacon”, to signify that, in an era of disruption, the industry, along with celebration, needs direction. Dheeraj Sinha, President of The Advertising Club and CEO McCann India, said, “Our seven-decade legacy carries both responsibility and opportunity, and with this brand refresh we are reaffirming our intent. Our new identity positions this body as a beacon in a time when volatility is high.”

Manoshij Banerjee
Mohammed Shahid Abdulla

Recently, when Prime Minister Narendra Modi appeared wearing a rare Roman Baagh watch, a customised timepiece featuring an authentic 1947 one-rupee coin, the choice was symbolic — of local craftsmanship, heritage, and identity wrapped around the wrist. It echoed a trend visible across India’s younger demographic: watches are transcending their utilitarian origins to become complex personal statements. Valued at \$4.62 billion in 2026 and projected to reach \$7.52 billion by 2031 (at 10.23 per cent CAGR), the watch sector in India is forcing brands to constantly negotiate between performance and appearance. Success depends on how homogeneously function is wrapped in identity and design.

SMALLER, BOLDER Preferences have shifted toward smaller, subtler dials. Yet, simultaneously, brighter colours, unconventional finishes, and “loud” designs are finding favour again, suggesting greater confidence in experimentation. The surge in demand for serpentine wraps, square and rectangular dials, asymmetrical cases, and integrated bracelet designs reinforces this pattern. The trend resonates beyond watches — eyewear brands like Lenskart report a growing demand for smaller frames paired with bolder colours, as consumers increasingly treat accessories as fashion-forward identity markers rather than purely functional aids.

This evolving taste connects directly to the ‘double wristing’ phenomenon — namely wearing a watch on both wrists. The justifications: tracking multiple time zones for global work collaborations, pairing a smartwatch’s fitness tracking with a mechanical watch’s aesthetic appeal, or simply celebrating horological interest. The fact that watches are now viewed as multifunctional accessories, rather than mere timepieces, has direct implications for how brands position products and how retailers stock inventory.

ANALOGUE HOLDOUT Smartwatches are projected to register 8.78 per cent CAGR through 2031, with premium models priced above ₹20,000 witnessing 147 per cent year-over-year growth. Google’s Pixel Watch 3 and Samsung’s Galaxy Watches with blood pressure and ECG monitoring cap-



ISTOCK

● WRIST PLAY

Gen Z’s watchword

SAYING IT WITH ACCESSORIES. Timepieces are becoming identity markers

abilities exemplify how health tracking and AI functionalities justifying premium pricing for younger buyers who view them as essential wellness companions. Yet, traditional quartz and analogue watches still command well over 50 per cent of market share. This isn’t resistance to technology. A 25-year-old software engineer in Bengaluru may check notifications on a Noise smartwatch during work hours and then switch to a Casio G-Shock for weekend adventures, with each choice communicating a different facet of identity. For brands, this dual appetite creates both opportunity and operational complexity. Average selling prices for budget wearables dropped from \$21 to \$19 over the past couple of years, compressing margins even as volumes grow. The response has been clear: push consumers toward mid-premium tiers, where differentiation through build quality, brand heritage, and after-sales service can justify higher prices and restore profitability. Swiss watch imports surged 40 per cent compared to 2021, driven partly by younger affluent consumers who view mechanical timepieces as both status symbols and tangible investments in an increasingly digital world. Brands must simultaneously compete in the high-volume, margin-compressed smartwatch space and

the premium analogue segments, where brand equity commands pricing power. Casio India recently commenced local manufacturing of 28 SKUs, with plans to expand annually, anticipating the country to become one of its top three global markets by the 2030s. Its watch business in India is growing by about one-third annually, fuelled by a desire to own multiple watches for different uses.

ORGANIC MARKETING The 377-million strong Gen Z prioritises authenticity, inclusivity, and community-driven narratives in its purchasing decisions. Traditional celebrity endorsements are losing ground to experiential marketing that feels organic rather than transactional. Take how domestic player Sylvi launched limited-edition collections under ₹2,000 through social media countdowns, creating urgency without requiring premium pricing. Timex’s ‘Waste More Time’ initiative and Fire-Bolt’s music festival partnerships exemplify how brands are engaging younger demographics through experiences rather than mere product upgrades. This generation discovered watches through social media rather than on parents’ wrists, creating distribution challenges that traditional retailers struggle to address. YouTube reviews, Instagram

unboxings, and Reddit communities shape purchasing decisions more than advertising.

TIER-2 EXPANSION The distribution landscape reflects Gen Z’s hybrid consumption habits, which may dictate where retailers allocate their expansion capital. While offline retail retained a bulk of the marketshare in 2025, online retail is projected to clock 9 per cent CAGR through 2031, driven by metropolitan and tier-2 consumers. Casio’s expansion of brand stores recognises a fundamental truth: younger consumers want seamless omnichannel experiences. This requires integrated inventory systems, consistent pricing across channels, and sales staff trained to assist customers who often know more about specifications than them. Tier-2 and tier-3 cities represent particularly fertile ground, with lower real-estate costs and less intense competition. These markets are witnessing smartwatch adoption just 15 percentage points below metro averages, a gap that is rapidly narrowing thanks to improved digital infrastructure and rising disposable incomes. For brands, the question isn’t whether to enter these markets but how quickly before competition intensifies. Enter too early, and infrastructure costs outpace revenue;

too late, and brand perception solidifies around competitors. **PREMIUMISATION** Perhaps the most consequential trend is “affordable premiumisation” — mid-tier offerings with features typically associated with luxury watches. Brands are adding ceramic bezels, AMOLED displays, and NFC payment capabilities to products priced economically, blurring category boundaries. This democratisation creates both opportunity and challenge. Consumers get sophisticated functionality and design at unprecedented prices. For brands, it means compressed margins in budget segments that were once reliably profitable. The response has been to use entry-level products for acquisition while actively migrating customers to mid-premium tiers through targeted marketing, trade-in programmes, and loyalty schemes. Timex Group India’s performance illustrates this strategy: high revenue and profit growth over the first half of FY26, achieved while actively pursuing M&A opportunities to strengthen its premium portfolio. The company recently launched Aston Martin watches alongside its acquisition of premium retailer Just Watches.

COLLECTION ECONOMY Millennial and Gen Z consumers reject false binaries. They don’t choose between analogue and digital, heritage and innovation, affordable and premium. Instead, they build personal collections that serve different needs — much like a Spotify playlist featuring indie punk, blues, and regional cinema soundtracks simultaneously. For new entrants, particularly domestic brands, the opportunity lies in identifying underserved persona-based collection niches like the “formal office watch under ₹15,000”, the “weekend adventure piece with Pride motifs”, or “Indie Luxury”. Brands that can own specific collection slots with authentic positioning will capture wallet share from consumers building a portfolio. Yet questions remain. How sustainable is growth predicated on consumers owning 3-5 watches when market reaches saturation? Can brands maintain premiumisation narratives as technology features commoditise at accelerating rates? How will the collection economy model reconcile with environmental concerns about consumption volume? Only time will tell.

Manoshij Banerjee is an independent consultant on digital content and behaviour, and Mohammed Shahid Abdulla is faculty member, IIM Kozhikode

● REWARDING EXCHANGE

How unused loyalty points can fund a child’s education

Chitra Narayanan

Brian Almeida, Founder of Points for Good, has designed and launched some of India’s most loved loyalty programmes — be it JetPrivilege, Taj Inner Circle, or Shoppers Stop First Citizen Club. Almeida is now trying to channelise loyalty points towards charitable causes.

What has changed in the loyalty business? In the loyalty industry, the biggest story we talk about is McDonald’s. For years on end, McDonald’s refused to do a loyalty programme. Two or three years ago, they

launched a loyalty programme globally. Everyone keeps asking me: Will loyalty die? My answer is that if you understand loyalty programmes as a structure, it is not dying but moving with the times. First, it was all about the ability to recognise a customer around the point of sale. It started with American Airlines, which recognised gold members, platinum members and so on. Then it gave you a tracking mechanism through the points currency. And then you got data — giving brands an ability to predict trends. Today, it is migrating into AI applications. Earlier we had to build the software. Now technology is readily available off the shelf.

What are the challenges that



POINT TAKEN. Brian Almeida, Founder, Points for Good

loyalty programmes face? Technology helps scale, but it increases sameness in the programme. The rewards portfolio is the same, so differentiation becomes a challenge. And brands al-

ways want to have that differentiation. The term we use is ‘emotional loyalty’. In India, most programmes would see 40-60 per cent of points expiring. If redemptions drop, it shows poor engagement with the individual. In North America, they target a high 80 per cent redemption and it makes sense, because if you’re not going to get your customers to engage, you’re investing in a white elephant of any technology, resources, processes within the organisation. The principle is that when a member redeems, they become more loyal to your brand, and transact more. So understanding that, we felt there was a gap.

How have you addressed it?

Dennis the Menace and the simple joys of childhood

What lies behind the timeless appeal of this iconic and endearing comic strip

THE CURIOUS
MARKETER



HARISH BHAT

Dennis the Menace turns 75 this month. This famous character and comic strip, first created in March 1951 by the American cartoonist Hank Ketcham, has appeared in over 1,000 newspapers across the world, charming millions of readers. I grew up happily with Dennis, laughing loudly at his little adventures. One of my most treasured possessions is a compilation of *Dennis the Menace* cartoons that appeared in 1951 and 1952. I bought this little fat book at the Strand Book Store in Mumbai, and turn to it quite often for solace and uninhibited happiness.

DENNIS’ APPEAL Despite turning 75, Dennis is still exactly five-and-a-half years old, as he has been ever since he was born. With his unruly shock of hair, impish freckled face and

striped black shirt, he creates such beautiful chaos at home and throughout his neighbourhood. His father, Henry Mitchell; his mother, Alice; his retired elderly neighbours George Wilson and wife, Martha — they are all targets of Dennis’ constant stream of activity. Dennis is a menace, but in a most appealing way.

What explains the enduring allure of this young boy across three generations? Despite living in a small American town (Wichita, in Kansas, is where Ketcham based Dennis), why does he appeal to people in different cultures across the world? Perhaps the simplest and most authentic answer comes from the cartoonist himself: “He makes people smile and laugh when they read his words and see his actions, which express an innocence shared universally by five-year-olds. Some things fortunately never change.”

WE LOVE TO LAUGH Ketcham’s answer contains two deep human truths. First, people love to smile and laugh. Even as the world around us lurches from



MENACE @75. Dennis the eternally lovable unruly kid

one crisis to another, even as we navigate through the ups and downs of life, a good laugh is always welcome. In fact, humour is essential to brighten our lives, and to lighten the burden of serious human existence. This is true not just of cartoon characters, but also brands in general. Brands that make people genuinely laugh do very well, regardless of the category they belong to. Think of Fevicol, for in-

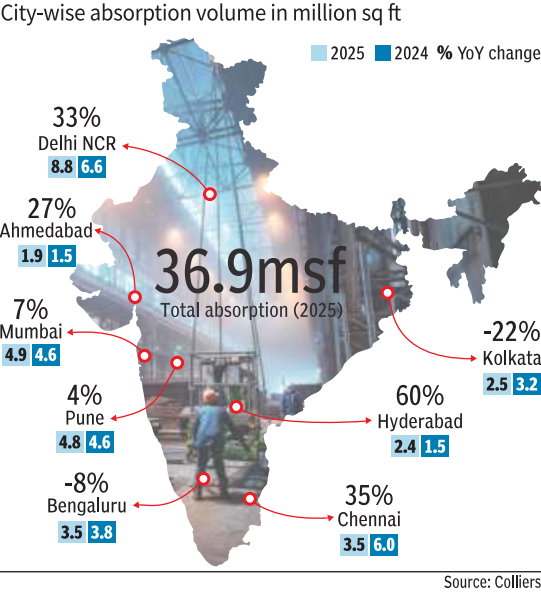
stance. It is an adhesive, but it’s signature communication campaigns are all about humour. And because of this, the brand has stuck on in our minds. Zomato is yet another new-age Indian brand that has repeatedly made us smile through its advertising. In fact, if your brand belongs to a “serious” product space, you can perhaps make it stand out by breaking the category code and injecting humour into what you say. Brands that pursue humour also gain from staying consistent with a wholesome, positive approach. Listen to what Ketcham said about his approach: “I make a point of staying away from the ugly side of life... I’d rather have upbeat things around me.”

THE CHILD WITHIN US A second human truth contained in Ketcham’s statement is that people are, in general, in love with the innocence of childhood. There is a five-year-old child deep within each of us. Some of us permit this child to surface often, and others keep it chained within the prison of adulthood. Either way, the inno-

cent frankness in what children say appeals greatly to us, because it is generally spontaneous, and often contains a kernel of the truth. Many adults would give a lot, I think, to becoming children once again, for at least a few days. Because the carefree, happy state of childhood is far preferable to the constant responsibilities of adulthood. Comic strips like *Dennis the Menace* take us into that five-year-old state for at least a few moments. This is also the reason why Disney is one of the world’s most powerful brands, amongst adults and kids alike. This is also the reason why RK Narayan’s novel *Swami and Friends*, which chronicles the life of six school-going children in a small town named Malgudi, is one of my all-time favourite books. For a moment, though, let us forget these marketing learnings and celebrate Dennis the Menace simply for what he is. A little boy who has given us so much pleasure with his adventures and antics. Happy 75th birthday, Dennis!

Harish Bhat is an avid marketer and bestselling author

Industrial and warehousing demand peaks across top eight cities in India



GLOBAL BYTES.

Don't target seafarers in war zone: IMO

Secretary-General of International Maritime Organization Arsenio Dominguez said on the reports of seafarer fatalities in West Asia, "I am alarmed and deeply saddened to hear of a deadly attack on a vessel in the Strait of Hormuz on March 6, 2026, in which at least four seafarers have reportedly lost their lives and three severely injured."

Due to the ongoing Iran-Israel war, around 20,000 seafarers remain stranded in the Persian Gulf, on board ships, under heightened risk and considerable mental



strain, the IMO said.

"This is unacceptable and unsustainable. All parties and stakeholders have an obligation to take necessary measures to ensure the protection of seafarers, including their rights and well-being, and the freedom of navigation, in accordance with international law," Dominguez said.

APAC aviation biz set to soar higher

In its latest global services forecast for Asia-Pacific (including China and India), Airbus anticipates that total services demand in the region will register 5.2 per cent compound annual growth rate (CAGR) through 2044, reaching an estimated market value of \$138.7 billion.

This sustained growth will be underpinned by expanding air traffic and fleet growth. Over the next 20 years, Asia-Pacific will require 19,560 new passenger aircraft, accounting for 46 per cent of total global demand during the forecast period. The region is also expected to remain the world's fastest-growing air travel market, with passenger traffic rising at 4.4 per cent annually, well above the global average of 3.6 per cent, the aircraft manufacturer said.



IN THE FRAME



INDIA-WEST ASIA CORRIDOR. DP World, the Dubai-based multinational logistics company, has augmented its connectivity and capacity across the India-West Asia corridor by acquiring and integrating a 5,000-plus TEU container vessel, *DP World Chennai*, into its marine services business Shipping Solutions. The company says it plans to invest \$5 billion in the coming years to strengthen its support for India's trade infrastructure. Shipping Solutions had earlier signed a memorandum of understanding with India's Sagarmala Finance Corporation Ltd to collaborate on developing and scaling up sustainable coastal and shortsea shipping services across the country.

RE POSTS.

- Standing Firm with Our Seafarers**

11 vessels involving 98 Indian seafarers have been successfully resolved on the International Labour Organization/ International Maritime Organization Joint Abandonment Database.

All affected seafarers have been repatriated and their wage dues settled in line with the Maritime Labour Convention (MLC, 2006).

Under the aegis of Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways (MoPSW), and through coordinated efforts with MEA, Flag States, PSC authorities, and RPSL companies, the Directorate General of Shipping remains committed to safeguarding the rights, dignity, and welfare of Indian seafarers worldwide.

We stand with our seafarers. Always.

Directorate General of Shipping, Govt. of India
@dgshipping_IN
- The Export Management System enables exporters to apply for licences, quotas and required registrations for restricted export items as notified by DGFT under the FTDR Act. The digital modules facilitate applications for export licences for restricted items, SCOMET items and licences issued under specific international arrangements. The system helps streamline regulatory compliance and ensures transparent and efficient export authorisation processes for Indian exporters.**

Dept of Commerce, GoI
@DoC_Goi

Avinash Nair

In the steel-and-glass corridors of GIFT City, a quiet aviation revolution is gaining altitude. In just one year, aircraft leasing from India's maiden international financial services centre, in Gandhinagar (Gujarat), has grown three-fold — a pace few other global hubs can claim. At the heart of this surge is a confluence of regulatory recalibration, dollar liquidity, tax clarity and, above all, India's insatiable appetite for flying.

At the end of December 2024, just 63 aircraft were leased from GIFT City. Fast-forward to December 2025, and that number has soared to 196 — a phenomenal 211 per cent jump. The tally includes 182 aircraft and 17 helicopters. By January this year, the number of aircraft leased rose to 198.

What makes this growth even more striking is that the number of aircraft lessors has grown just 13 per cent in the same period. The number of aircraft engines leased has grown 68 per cent, while that of aircraft auxiliary power units (APUs) has risen 6 per cent. In other words, the ecosystem is not merely expanding in terms of participants but also scaling up in asset depth. The aircraft leased so far are valued at \$6.886 billion. Meanwhile, aircraft leasing entities have received \$615 million financing from the IFSC banking units (IBUs) operating within GIFT City.

For K Rajaraman, Chairperson of International Financial Services Centres Authority (IFSCA), the momentum is structural — not episodic. "A majority of aircraft continue to be deployed with Indian airlines due to strong domestic growth. In fact, Indian airlines have placed the largest orders to OEMs globally. However, overseas leasing is picking up for smaller aircraft — some entities have leased smaller aircraft to select Asian markets. Leasing of trainer aircraft is also expected to scale up as existing FTOs (flight training organisations) scale up and new FTOs get established. IFSCA is strengthening supervisory data frameworks on geographic exposure," Rajaraman said.

GIFT City's aircraft leasing ecosystem has evolved rapidly since the first transaction in 2021, when Vman Aero Services leased an Airbus H125 helicopter to Thumbay Aviation; and JetSetFleet Management Services IFSC Ltd, the leasing arm of JetSetGo Aviation, imported a Hawker 800XP business jet. Soon, players such as Air India's AI Fleet Services Ltd, InterGlobe Aviation and Astraevs Services IFSC Ltd established or expanded



● GIFT CITY

Aircraft leasing gains altitude

Financial hub spreads wings in aviation funding

aviation leasing and financing operations at the IFSC, alongside a growing number of domestic and international lessors routing aircraft financing structures through GIFT City.

ROLE OF BANKS

But the story is no longer just about facilitating leases. The banking and capital market ecosystem at GIFT IFSC is increasingly supporting aviation financing. "Syndication and secondary sales of loans are also picking up," Rajaraman said.

This growing activity is helping deepen liquidity in the aviation debt markets at the IFSC. Rajaraman pointed out that a larger share of aircraft acquisitions is now being routed through IFSC entities, signalling a shift from simple lease intermediation to asset ownership, structured portfolio investments and balance sheet-led financing.

Such structures could open the door to secondary market activity, refinancing and asset-backed financing, allowing long-term institutional investors to participate, while improving risk diversification across the ecosystem. Access to competitive dollar funding has long been a key advantage for established global leasing hubs such as Dublin and Singapore.

Aviation asset leasing surges in volume and value at GIFT City

Type of asset	as on Dec 31, 2024	as on Dec 31, 2025
Aircraft	63	196
Engines	53	89
Aircraft auxiliary power units	80	85
Total aviation assets leased	196	370
Total aircraft lessors	30	34
• Value of aircraft leased — \$6.886 billion		
• Aircraft financing — \$3.712 billion		
• Aircraft financing received from international banking units — \$615 million		

GIFT IFSC, Rajaraman said, is steadily closing that gap. "The availability of dollar funding has strengthened materially with the growing presence of global and regional banks at GIFT IFSC," he said. Japanese, West Asian and Indian banks have established IBUs, which increasingly offer aviation-focused lending and structured credit.

As a result, financing structures such

● FARM LOGISTICS

An export grid that bears fruit



PARASHRAM PATIL

The west coast of India has long been recognised for its strong agricultural base. The region produces a rich basket of commodities — rice, ragi, pulses, coconut, areca nut, spices, and high-value horticultural crops such as Alphonso mango, cashew, jackfruit, and fisheries products — many of which enjoy strong domestic and export demand. Yet, despite this natural advantage, the region's export potential has historically been constrained by infrastructural and logistical gaps, most notably the absence of local certification and testing facilities.

For decades, agricultural exporters from Maharashtra, Karnataka, Goa, Andhra Pradesh, and Telangana, among other states, were forced to depend on Jawaharlal Nehru Port Trust (JNPT). For instance, Konkan mango was exported from JNPT nearly 500 km away, leading to a higher transportation cost of ₹60,000 per container and a two-day transit delay at minimum. The distance also compromised the freshness of perishables, while congestion and seasonal bottlenecks added layers of uncertainty.

A TURNING POINT

The recent inauguration of a plant quarantine office and an NABL-ac-

credited FSSAI laboratory at Jaigad Port marks a decisive shift for agri exports. The facilities were established through the collaborative efforts of the Maharashtra Maritime Board, Maharashtra Information Transformation (MITRA), and the Cashew Board. Farmers, fishermen, and exporters across Konkan and Western Maharashtra can access essential testing, inspection, and certification services locally, reducing time, fuel consumption, and transportation expenditure while strengthening compliance with export standards

Jaigad Port's strategic advantages offer this benefit for Konkan's diversified agricultural economy. The modern, mechanised deep-water facility offers a capacity of 55 million tonnes per annum (expandable to 70 MTPA), an all-season deep-draught cargo capability, existing warehousing and cold storage infrastructure, and connectivity to hinterland regions — Kolhapur, Satara, Sangli, Solapur, and North Karnataka. Studies indicate that logistics costs could decline by 10–15 per cent, strengthening the global competitiveness of the region's flagship commodities such as Alphonso mango and Konkan cashew.

Neighbouring states, too, can benefit through the creation of a more efficient, less congested, and cost-effective west-coast export corridor. For Goa, the port offers a faster export for cashew, coconut products, horticulture, and fisheries, reducing dependence on Mormugao Port and the congested JNPT.



FRESH OFF THE BOAT. Alphonso mango, the 'king' of agri exports ISTOCK

● GIANT-IN-WAITING

GMS seeks EU nod for Indian ship recyclers



STEELY RESERVE. Alang, in Gujarat, boasts annual ship recycling capacity of 4.5 million LDT VIJAY SONEJI

T E Raja Simhan

GMS, the world's largest buyer of ships for recycling, has urged the European Commission to approve qualified Indian ship recycling facilities for inclusion in the European list under the European Union Ship Recycling Regulation.

Despite more than 110 Indian yards holding Hong Kong Convention (HKC) Statements of Compliance issued by IACS member classification societies, over 35 formal applications, and at least 10 commission-led inspections and audits, not a single Indian yard has been approved in more than a decade. This is not a failure of standards or verification. It is a failure of political will, said the Dubai-based GMS.

India has dismantled over 8,500 vessels across four decades, recovering more than 67 million tonnes of steel. Alang's annual recycling capacity — about 4.5 million light displacement tonnes — exceeds the combined capacity of the facilities currently in the European list.

A lifecycle analysis by GMS shows that 75 per cent of the hull steel recycled at Alang is directly re-rolled into plate and beam without energy-intensive melting. This reduces carbon dioxide emissions by 58 per cent, compared with virgin steel production. Indian yards recover more than 98 per cent of all ship materials, GMS said.

Most European facilities melt recovered steel and export scrap to Asia. The environmental narrative presented in Brussels does not align with the underlying carbon arithmetic. The commission's refusal to list Indian yards is based on the Basel Convention's Ban Amendment, which restricts hazardous waste exports from OECD to non-OECD countries. The framework predates Indian yards' current transformation by decades.

"The yards at Alang have retrained thousands of workers, rebuilt infrastructure and achieved one of the lowest lifecycle carbon footprints of any major recycling model globally. The European Commission continues to withhold approval without transparent justification. This undermines the credibility of the EU's sustainability objectives," says Kiran Thorat, Trader, GMS.

GMS urges the commission to approve qualified Indian yards without further delay, recognise the HKC as the primary global ship recycling framework, and resolve the Basel-HKC regulatory conflict through facility-level assessments rather than geographic exclusion. According to BIMCO, nearly 15,000 vessels will require recycling by 2032. The European list does not have the capacity for it. Meanwhile, 15,000 direct and 5,00,000 indirect livelihoods depend on India's recycling ecosystem.

The writer is an agricultural economist

We value your feedback. Do send your comments to bl.logistics@thehindu.co.in

MY FIVE.

DIVYE AGARWAL
Co-Founder, Binge Labs



Hydration, protein, and AI as pocket nutritionist

- 1 Hydration travels with me: I take nearly 60 to 70 flights a year, so I always carry electrolytes to prevent dehydration, sustain energy and reduce travel fatigue.
- 2 Protein is non-negotiable: Meals are often irregular. I keep protein bars with me at all times to avoid energy crashes and maintain adequate protein intake.
- 3 Play for two hours weekly: Sports are my biggest anchor for fitness and mental clarity. I play badminton or cricket for at least two hours every week — it keeps me agile, competitive and mentally sharp. No matter how busy your schedule is, you can always find a couple of hours over the weekend to play.
- 4 Targeted strength: Structured gym workouts help me stay consistent despite a hectic schedule. Training at night works best for me. I prioritise three to four focused sessions for strength and conditioning each week, to build endurance.
- 5 AI for health choices: Artificial intelligence works like a pocket nutritionist during busy days. I use AI tools like ChatGPT or Gemini as a quick reference for nutrition and energy management during busy days.

CAPSULE.

Chile ends leprosy

The World Health Organization (WHO) and Pan American Health Organization (PAHO) have lauded Chile's achievement as the first country in the Americas



— and second globally — to be officially verified as leprosy-free. Jordan was the first globally. Leprosy (Hansen disease) is a chronic infectious disease caused by the bacterium *Mycobacterium leprae*. It was historically recorded in Chile, end-19th century, on Rapa Nui (Easter Island). The disease was limited in mainland Chile, with sporadic introductions contained through isolation and treatment measures in the island, where the last secondary cases were managed by late 1990s.

Chile has not reported any locally acquired leprosy case for more than 30 years. The disease was never removed from the country's public health agenda.

The verification recognises more than three decades of sustained public health action, robust surveillance, long-term political commitment, and a health system that has remained vigilant even in the absence of local transmission, the WHO said.

At the request of Chile's Ministry of Health, PAHO and WHO convened an independent expert panel in 2025 to assess whether elimination had been achieved and could be sustained over time. Its findings confirmed the absence of local transmission and validated Chile's capacity to detect and respond to future cases.

COMING UP.

Healthy kidney, safe planet

Chronic kidney disease affects one in 10 people globally, says the International Society of Nephrology, which, along with the International Federation of Kidney Foundations — World Kidney Alliance, annually marks the second Thursday of March as World Kidney Day. Falling on March 12 this year, it is themed 'Kidney health for all — Caring for people, protecting the planet'.

● PREVENTIVE PUSH

Moving the needle to the elderly

TABS ON JABS. Fault lines appear as vaccination campaigns move beyond babies to older cohorts

PT Jyothi Datta

In the last two months, at least three vaccines for adults have been in the news, in addition to one high-profile campaign to vaccinate 14-year-old girls.

For a country that has run childhood immunisation programmes for decades now, this signals the intent of the Centre and some states' to extend vaccination campaigns beyond infants, to young people and adults. And the government and private sector are driving conversations on vaccines as a preventive against strains of the human papillomavirus (HPV) that cause cervical cancer; pneumonia/ flu; and shingles, caused by reactivation of the varicella-zoster virus that causes chicken pox.

Late February, the HPV vaccination campaign covering 14-year-old girls was launched by Prime Minister Narendra Modi. Days before this, the Centre launched a tetanus and adult diphtheria (Td) vaccine made for the first time in a government set-up — the Central Research Institute in Kasauli, Himachal Pradesh. In the private market, drugmaker GlaxoSmithKline sought to raise awareness on shingles. Its vaccine for those over 50 years is close to clocking three years in India.

Earlier this year, Kerala marked a first of sorts in budgeting for a pneumococcal vaccination programme for older people. At present, India does not run campaigns to vaccinate its elderly against pneumonia and flu, unlike Western countries that have an annual flu vaccine.

The Covid-19 pandemic was possibly the only time the Centre had taken intensive steps to vaccinate young people and adults. The experience, though, resulted in fault lines appearing between those who campaign for vaccination as an effective preventive step and those who campaign to keep the exercise optional.

ACROSS AGES

Dr Soumya Swaminathan, former Chief Scientist with the World



LIFE-COURSE PREVENTION. Immunisation addresses different needs and risks at different ages ISTOCK

Health Organization, explains, "You have to look at immunisation as a life-course prevention activity... it's not only for children, but also all ages and stages of life — there are different needs and different risks at different ages."

The tetanus and diphtheria vaccines are for adults, once in 10 years to maintain immunity, says Swaminathan, Chairperson, MS Swaminathan Research Foundation. Vaccines for older people include the annual influenza vaccine, Covid booster recommended in many countries (not India), the pneumococcal vaccine (against pneumonia), says Swaminathan.

"We are at a point in the country's immunisation history where they are shifting not just from looking at children but young adults and elderly as well," she observes.

But there is a need for research and development to make multi-antigen (combination) vaccines to avoid taking four or five different ones, she says. India has a population that's slowly ageing and "we've got to think about healthy ageing", she adds.

Not only are the elderly prone

to infection, flu/ pneumococcal and shingles, but data also shows that certain chronic diseases arrive in India about 10 years earlier than in Western countries, says Dr Shalini Menon, Executive Vice President (Medical Affairs), GSK India. Stressing the need for an ecosystem to administer adult vaccinations, including addressing apprehensions, she says people need to take informed decisions on their own.

A worried G Venugopalan, who lost his 20-year-old daughter allegedly due to an adverse event linked to the Covid vaccine, questions the need for the adult vaccination campaigns. Pointing to the HPV campaign, he calls for "full disclosure and informed consent" in all public health measures. People are on their own when something goes wrong, he had posted online, urging everyone to discuss and fully understand the safety and efficacy of these vaccines.

'PIN CUSHIONS'

On whether the elderly are now becoming "pin cushions" (with multiple vaccinations), Swaminathan says every available vaccine cannot be introduced in

● FROM THE REGULATOR

Citizen-led Canadian health strategy for men and boys



ISTOCK

The government of Canada is inviting citizens to help shape the country's first 'Men and boys' health strategy' by completing an online questionnaire.

The process runs from March to June 1, allowing people across the country to share their perspectives, experiences and ideas on ways to better support the physical and mental well-being of men and boys.

The feedback will help develop a national strategy for improving men's well-being and health outcomes by encouraging supportive and safe environments, challenging harmful stereotypes, reducing stigma and encouraging men of all ages to seek help when they need it.

The questionnaire is part of a broader national engagement that was launched in February to gather insights from the public. While many men and boys face significant physical and mental health challenges, these issues have too often been overlooked, misunderstood or ignored. Supporting men's well-being not only improves their lives, but also strengthens families, communities and workplaces to positively impact all Canadians. Improved men's health in Canada could save \$12.4 billion annually, with billions more in increased productivity.

Men are three times more likely than women to die by suicide or develop gambling problems, and about 28 per cent of men meet the criteria for a substance use disorder in their lifetime. Between July 2024 and June 2025, about 72 per cent of all apparent opioid toxicity deaths were among males. Concerning social trends, including harmful online spaces (like the "manosphere"), and social isolation are increasing the health risks for boys and men.

In 2021, men were twice as likely to die from preventable causes than women. Men are less likely than women to engage with primary care or access preventive services, including health screening. About 65 per cent of Canadian men wait more than six days with symptoms before visiting the doctor.

Source: Health Canada

What women want... from health insurance coverage

BY INVITATION



AMIT CHHABRA

For a long time, several aspects of women's health remained under-recognised in medical research and financial protection systems.

Medical issues such as polycystic ovarian disease (PCOD) and endometriosis were rarely spoken about openly due to social stigma. This also led to women being underrepresented in insurance coverage aspects, until policy changes in the early 1990s began recognising and correcting this imbalance. Between then and now, digital access and awareness have acted as a bridge for many women, who actively track their health and ensure their health insurance reflects their needs.

Health insurance is now designed for women consumers who are reading the fine print and asking questions. Is OPD (outpatient department) service included? Is preventive screening covered? What about polycystic ovary syndrome (PCOS) management? Or mental healthcare?

Our data reflects this shift — women's participation as policy proposers in health insurance has risen from 15 per cent in FY23 to 22 per cent in FY25. Also, nearly 75 per cent now opt for a sum insured of ₹10 lakh and above, indicating that women are recognising the real impact of inflation on medical bills and choosing realistic coverage, especially in the metros.

The common perception was that health insurance was needed when something went wrong, like a sudden surgery or any other emergency. Not anymore.

For women in their 20s and 30s, the focus tends to be on maternity benefits, reproductive health, and preventive care. By their 40s and 50s, priorities shift toward higher sum insured (with many opting for ₹25-plus lakh). They are also increasingly choosing ₹1 crore coverage, often pairing it with super top-up plans to keep it financially manageable. Post 50, the focus moves to critical illness riders and shorter waiting periods for



ISTOCK

pre-existing conditions.

The change is also visible in the way the insurance industry now designs plans. Maternity waiting period, once as long as 2-4 years, is now cut to three months in some plans. This essentially means that one can opt for maternity plans once they know they are expecting. Coverage for PCOS, earlier excluded from standard plans, is finding its way into mainstream offerings. Preventive screenings, OPD consultations, cervical health check-ups, and mental health support are increasingly being covered. The industry still has ground to cover, but the direction is right. And women demanding better products is a large part of the reason.

BEYOND METROS

While metros like Delhi, Mumbai, Bengaluru, Hyderabad, and Chennai continue to lead in adoption, the growth story is increasingly being written elsewhere. Currently, 46 per cent of women's health insurance purchases comes from tier 1 cities, 34 per cent from tier 2, and 20 per cent from tier 3 cities. It's worth pausing over the fact that one in five purchases now comes from tier 3 markets. The same health conversations happening in Mumbai are now reaching women in Meerut and Madurai, breaking down geographical barriers. The gap between what women need and what the market offers continues to narrow. This Women's Day, perhaps the most powerful change underway is that women are treating health insurance not as an obligation, but self-care.

The writer is Chief Business Officer-General Insurance, Policybazaar. Views are personal

LENS ON HEALTH



ANTI-SOCIAL WEB. Parents hold images of their children, who were harmed by social media, during a House Energy and Commerce Committee markup of nine bills, including the Kids Internet and Digital Safety (KIDS) Act, on Capitol Hill in Washington, DC REUTERS

Investing in women's wellbeing beyond maternity

Midlife, ageing, mental health, and chronic disease prevention remain areas of darkness in health policies for women



ANGELA CHAUDHURI

Every year, International Women's Day brings renewed attention to maternal health, reproductive rights, and gender equity. These are vital concerns. Yet, the framing of women's health often begins and ends with motherhood.

Even after their reproductive years, women shoulder caregiving responsibilities, thus becoming the backbone of health systems. Their health, therefore, is a structural determinant of societal stability.

Non-communicable diseases are the leading cause of death among women. The World Health Organization (WHO) says cardiovascular diseases account for nearly 35

per cent of deaths among women worldwide. Yet, public discourse, and even policy investment often concentrate on maternal indicators while neglecting midlife, ageing, mental health, and chronic disease prevention among women.

Studies across multiple regions show that women prioritise family members' health over their own, especially in low- and middle-income settings. In India, data from the National Family Health Survey (NFHS) repeatedly show gender gaps in access to nutrition, health services, and decision-making autonomy within households.

CARE ECONOMY

The International Labour Organization estimates that women perform three-quarters of unpaid care work globally. Childcare, eldercare, food preparation, water collection, and health monitoring within households are essential to



INVISIBILISATION. Women perform three-quarters of unpaid care work globally KR DEEPAK

public health functioning but are not captured in gross domestic product calculations.

Even when employed, women have to manage expanded care responsibilities at home. This was observed especially in women healthcare workers

during the Covid pandemic. WHO has since included burnout as an occupational phenomenon resulting from chronic workplace stress.

Health systems do not adequately invest in women's long-term wellbeing beyond maternity. A more holistic approach is urgently needed. First, health policy must adopt a life-course framework for women. This means integrating into primary health systems cardiovascular screening, metabolic health, cancer prevention beyond cervical and breast cancer, mental health services, and menopause care. Preventive cardiovascular screening is shown to reduce morbidity and mortality. This can also be adapted for resource-constrained settings.

Second, unpaid care work must be recognised as a public health variable. Social protection policies, paid family leave, community childcare systems, and eldercare support reduce

caregiver strain and improve mental health outcomes. The Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development has documented the economic and wellbeing benefits of family-friendly labour policies in member states. Emerging evidence from Asia suggests similar patterns.

Third, leadership parity in health governance is essential. The Lancet Commission on Women and Health has highlighted the link between women's political representation and improved social sector investment. Diverse leadership broadens the health agenda beyond maternal metrics.

Finally, public narratives must shift. Women are not only caregivers and mothers. They are workers, leaders, and citizens, whose health trajectories shape economic and intergenerational wellbeing.

The writer is Chief Catalyst at Swasti, an India-headquartered public health agency



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